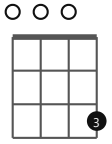
The Wild Rover

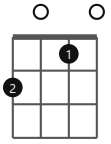
Traditional

Key: **C major** Time: **3/4** Tempo: **120 bpm** Strum: **D>-DUDU** Starts on: **C (I)**

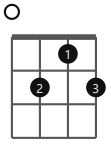
THE CHORDS IN C, AND HOW THEY FEEL



C
I
home



F
IV
away



G7
V7
tension (wants to go home)

THE SONG

A Verse 1 *I've been a...* → **B** Chorus *And it's no...* → **A** Verse 2 *I went to...* → **B** Chorus *And it's no...* → **A** Verse 3 *I took from...* → **B** Chorus *And it's no...* → **A** Verse 4 *I'll go home...* → **B** Chorus *And it's no...*

- The three-chord trick: just one, four and five.
- 8 parts in the song, but only 2 different chord patterns to learn.
- The verse (A) comes 4 times: learn that first.

CHORD MAP

A Verse ×4, new words each time

I've been a wild rover for...	**C** I ①	**F** IV	**C** I ②	
And I've spent all me money...	**C** I	**G7** V7	**C** I	
But now I'm returning with gold...	**C** I	**F** IV	**C** I	**F** IV
And I never will play the...	**C** I	**G7** V7	**C** I	

① **Three-chord trick**: C F C G7, I IV I V, in the line "I've been a wild rover for...". One, four, back home, five: wants to go home again.

② **Home and away**: C G7 C, I V I, in the line "I've been a wild rover for...". Just one and five: home, away, home ("Clementine", "Jambalaya").

B Chorus ×4, the same words each time

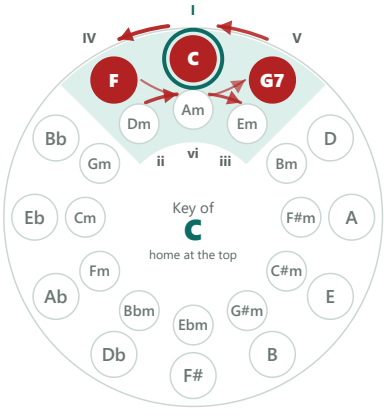
And it's no, nay, never, (clap…	**G7** V7	**C** I ①
No, nay, never, no more,	**F** IV	
Will I play the wild rover,	**C** I ②	**F** IV
No never, no more.	**G7** V7	**C** I

① **Amen (plagal)**: C F C, I IV I, in the line "And it's no, nay, never, (clap…". One, four, one: the "A-men" sound.
② **Three-chord trick**: C F G7 C, I IV V I (as before).

CHANGES TO PRACTISE

1. **C → G7** (×12): Slide your ring finger along the A string to the 2nd fret; put your index finger on the E string, 1st fret; put your middle finger on the C string, 2nd fret.
2. **F → G7** (×4): Keep your index finger where it is (E string, 1st fret); move your middle finger to the C string, 2nd fret; put your ring finger on the A string, 2nd fret.
3. **C → F** (×20): Put your index finger on the E string, 1st fret; put your middle finger on the G string, 2nd fret; lift your ring finger.
4. **G7 → C** (×16): Slide your ring finger along the A string to the 3rd fret; lift your index finger; lift your middle finger.
5. **F → C** (×16): Put your ring finger on the A string, 3rd fret; lift your index finger; lift your middle finger.

ON THE CIRCLE OF FIFTHS



- Home is C, ringed at the top. Its closest chords sit either side: IV to the left, V to the right, and the minors ii, vi and iii inside.
- All 3 of its chords sit in the key's family (the shaded part), so it all belongs together.
- C → F (I → IV), 20 times: one step anticlockwise (down a fifth): the way music likes to move.
- F → C (IV → I), 16 times: four to one, the "Amen" sound.
- G7 → C (V7 → I), 16 times: five to one: the strongest pull home.
- C → G7 (I → V7), 12 times: from home out to five: the tension that pulls straight back.

LEARNING IT

1. Practise the hardest changes above until they're smooth (Learn → Changes…).
2. Play along with the chords, then **from memory**: the chords hidden after the first time each part comes, then as numbers only, then none (Learn → From memory).
3. Play it in another key, thinking in numbers. If you can, you know the song, not just the shapes.
4. Come back to it in a day or two, and again in a week.

TROUBLE SPOTS

Made with ukemusic on 6 Nov 2026.